

# Scaling

## CSI4106 Introduction to Artificial Intelligence

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### Scenario

We pretend to predict a house price using **k-Nearest Neighbors (KNN) regression** with two features:

- $x_1$ : number of rooms (small scale)
- $x_2$ : square footage (large scale)

We create three examples **a**, **b**, **c** chosen so that:

- **Without scaling**, **a** is closer to **b** (because square footage dominates).
- **With scaling (z-score)**, **a** becomes closer to **c** (rooms difference matters after rescaling).

### Data (three houses)

```
import numpy as np
import pandas as pd

# Three examples (rooms, sqft); prices only for b and c (training)
point_names = ["a", "b", "c"]
X = np.array([
    [4, 1500.0], # a (query)
    [8, 1520.0], # b (train)
    [4, 1300.0], # c (train)
], dtype=float)

prices = pd.Series([np.nan, 520_000, 390_000], index=point_names, name="price")
```

```
df = pd.DataFrame(X, columns=["rooms", "sqft"], index=point_names)
display(df)
display(prices.to_frame())
```

|   | rooms | sqft   |
|---|-------|--------|
| a | 4.0   | 1500.0 |
| b | 8.0   | 1520.0 |
| c | 4.0   | 1300.0 |

|   | price    |
|---|----------|
| a | NaN      |
| b | 520000.0 |
| c | 390000.0 |

**Note.** We'll treat **b** and **c** as the training set, and **a** as the query whose price we want to predict.

### Euclidean distances (unscaled)

The (squared) Euclidean distance between  $u$  and  $v$  is

$$\|u - v\|_2^2 = \sum_j (u_j - v_j)^2.$$

When one feature has a much larger scale (e.g., square footage), it can dominate the sum.

```
from sklearn.metrics import pairwise_distances

dist_unscaled = pd.DataFrame(
    pairwise_distances(df.values, metric="euclidean"),
    index=df.index, columns=df.index
)
dist_unscaled
```

|   | a         | b         | c          |
|---|-----------|-----------|------------|
| a | 0.000000  | 20.396078 | 200.000000 |
| b | 20.396078 | 0.000000  | 220.036361 |

|   | a          | b          | c        |
|---|------------|------------|----------|
| c | 200.000000 | 220.036361 | 0.000000 |

```
print("Nearest to 'a' (unscaled):", dist_unscaled.loc["a"].drop("a").idxmin())
```

Nearest to 'a' (unscaled): b

*Expectation:* **a** is nearest to **b** (similar sqft overwhelms rooms).

## Proper scaling for modeling (fit scaler on the training set)

For a fair ML workflow, compute scaling parameters on the training data (**b**, **c**) only, then transform both train and query:

$$z(x) = \frac{x - \mu_{\text{train}}}{\sigma_{\text{train}}}.$$

```
from sklearn.preprocessing import StandardScaler

train_idx = ["b", "c"]
query_idx = ["a"]

scaler = StandardScaler()

scaler.fit(df.loc[train_idx])    # fit only on training points

Z = pd.DataFrame(
    scaler.transform(df),
    columns=df.columns, index=df.index
)

Z
```

|   | rooms | sqft      |
|---|-------|-----------|
| a | -1.0  | 0.818182  |
| b | 1.0   | 1.000000  |
| c | -1.0  | -1.000000 |

## Euclidean distances (after scaling)

```
dist_scaled = pd.DataFrame(  
    pairwise_distances(Z.values, metric="euclidean"),  
    index=Z.index, columns=Z.index  
)  
dist_scaled
```

|   | a        | b        | c        |
|---|----------|----------|----------|
| a | 0.000000 | 2.008247 | 1.818182 |
| b | 2.008247 | 0.000000 | 2.828427 |
| c | 1.818182 | 2.828427 | 0.000000 |

```
print("Nearest to 'a' (scaled):", dist_scaled.loc["a"].drop("a").idxmin())
```

Nearest to 'a' (scaled): c

*Now: a is nearest to c (rooms difference matters once features are on comparable scales).*

## KNN regressor: flip in the prediction

We'll run a 1-NN regressor (so the prediction is exactly the nearest neighbor's price) **with and without** scaling.

```
from sklearn.neighbors import KNeighborsRegressor  
from sklearn.pipeline import Pipeline  
  
X_train = df.loc[train_idx].values      # b, c  
y_train = prices.loc[train_idx].values  # prices for b, c  
X_query = df.loc[query_idx].values      # a  
  
# 1) No scaling  
knn_plain = KNeighborsRegressor(n_neighbors=1, metric="euclidean")  
knn_plain.fit(X_train, y_train)  
pred_plain = knn_plain.predict(X_query)[0]  
  
# 2) With scaling (pipeline fits scaler only on training, then KNN on scaled)  
knn_scaled = Pipeline([
```

```

    ("scaler", StandardScaler()),
    ("knn", KNeighborsRegressor(n_neighbors=1, metric="euclidean"))
])
knn_scaled.fit(X_train, y_train)
pred_scaled = knn_scaled.predict(X_query)[0]

pd.DataFrame(
    {
        "prediction (no scaling)": [pred_plain],
        "prediction (with scaling)": [pred_scaled],
        "nearest neighbor (no scaling)": [point_names[1] if pred_plain==prices['b'] else point_names[0]],
        "nearest neighbor (with scaling)": [point_names[1] if pred_scaled==prices['b'] else point_names[0]]
    },
    index=["a"]
)

```

|   | prediction (no scaling) | prediction (with scaling) | nearest neighbor (no scaling) | nearest neighbor (with scaling) |
|---|-------------------------|---------------------------|-------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| a | 520000.0                | 390000.0                  | b                             | c                               |

### Takeaway:

- **Unscaled:** a b prediction **\$520,000**
- **Scaled:** a c prediction **\$390,000**

Same model and data; just **feature scale** changed the neighbor—and the prediction.

### Why this happens

- (Squared) Euclidean distance aggregates per-feature squared differences:

$$|u - v|_2^2 = \sum_j (u_j - v_j)^2.$$

- A large-scale feature (e.g., **sqft**) can dwarf small-scale features (e.g., **rooms**), so KNN effectively “ignores” the smaller-scale dimensions.
- **Standardization** ( $z$ -scores) or **min-max scaling** puts dimensions on comparable footing.
- **Rule of thumb:** For distance-based methods (KNN, k-means, RBF kernels, etc.), always **scale** features.

## Show the distance to neighbors only

Distances from **a** to {**b**, **c**} before and after scaling.

```
def show_pair(name_from, names_to, D):  
    return D.loc[name_from, names_to].to_frame("distance")  
  
print("Unscaled distances from a → {b,c}")  
display(show_pair("a", ["b", "c"], dist_unscaled))  
  
print("Scaled distances from a → {b,c}")  
display(show_pair("a", ["b", "c"], dist_scaled))
```

Unscaled distances from a → {b,c}

|   | distance   |
|---|------------|
| b | 20.396078  |
| c | 200.000000 |

Scaled distances from a → {b,c}

|   | distance |
|---|----------|
| b | 2.008247 |
| c | 1.818182 |

## Switch to Manhattan distance?

Even with  $L_1$  distance, scale still matters:

$$|u - v|_1 = \sum_j |u_j - v_j|.$$

Try replacing `metric="euclidean"` with `metric="manhattan"`—you'll see the same sensitivity to feature scale.

```

from sklearn.neighbors import KNeighborsRegressor
from sklearn.pipeline import Pipeline

X_train = df.loc[train_idx].values      # b, c
y_train = prices.loc[train_idx].values  # prices for b, c
X_query = df.loc[query_idx].values      # a

# 1) No scaling
knn_plain = KNeighborsRegressor(n_neighbors=1, metric="manhattan")
knn_plain.fit(X_train, y_train)
pred_plain = knn_plain.predict(X_query)[0]

# 2) With scaling (pipeline fits scaler only on training, then KNN on scaled)
knn_scaled = Pipeline([
    ("scaler", StandardScaler()),
    ("knn", KNeighborsRegressor(n_neighbors=1, metric="manhattan"))
])
knn_scaled.fit(X_train, y_train)
pred_scaled = knn_scaled.predict(X_query)[0]

pd.DataFrame(
    {
        "prediction (no scaling)": [pred_plain],
        "prediction (with scaling)": [pred_scaled],
        "nearest neighbor (no scaling)": [point_names[1] if pred_plain==prices['b'] else point_names[0] if pred_plain==prices['c'] else point_names[2]],
        "nearest neighbor (with scaling)": [point_names[1] if pred_scaled==prices['b'] else point_names[0] if pred_scaled==prices['c'] else point_names[2]]
    },
    index=["a"]
)

```

|   | prediction (no scaling) | prediction (with scaling) | nearest neighbor (no scaling) | nearest neighbor (with scaling) |
|---|-------------------------|---------------------------|-------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| a | 520000.0                | 390000.0                  | b                             | c                               |

## TL;DR

- **Distance-based models** are highly sensitive to **feature scales**.
- **Always scale** your inputs (fit the scaler on the **training** set only).
- Scaling can **change nearest neighbors** and therefore **change predictions**—as seen here with 1-NN regression.